

But there remained the problem of finding brokers to trade through. Following the stock market crash in 2001, brokers who had dealt for Ketan had suffered huge losses. And since his bank accounts were frozen and investigative agencies were closely watching his every move, Ketan could not repay them legally, even if he wanted to.

So he made them a proposal. He would trade through them using fronts. If he profited on the trade, a chunk of that money would go towards repaying his debt. The only way his erstwhile brokers could hope to recoup the money Ketan owed them was to execute his trades. If he lost money on the trade, the broker got nothing, and what was more, he could not complain to the regulator either. After all, Ketan should not have been allowed to trade in the first place.

Still, many brokers took up the offer.

To my surprise, Monk refused to do business with Ketan until his previous dues were cleared.

I asked Monk why.

‘Ketan had planned his game very well,’ Monk told me. ‘Having been in the business of trading for so long, he knew that no trader, however skilled or lucky, could escape the law of averages. In his case, he knew that the losses would be huge enough to wipe out his net worth, given the outsized bets he was taking. While agreeing to manipulate the stocks of a few promoters, he prevailed on them to allot him a good chunk of shares from their *benami* accounts at throwaway prices. Of those, he transferred a sizeable portion to his accounts abroad masquerading as OCBs.

‘He used the rest of the shares to generate artificial volumes in the stock through circular trading. Finally, when the technology bubble burst globally, Ketan knew he would no longer be able to support the inflated prices of his favourite stocks. He then played his final card. He placed orders with his brokers, including me, to buy shares of the companies he had been manipulating. We bought the shares, unaware that the sellers of those shares were overseas entities controlled by Ketan.’ I could sense the bitterness in Monk’s tone.

He did not have to complete the story for me; I could see how the story would have played out. On the day of settlement, the money was debited from the brokers’ accounts by the stock exchange towards the payment for the shares. Unknown to the brokers, the money flowed into the ‘foreign investors’ accounts and out of the country. When the brokers approached